TapSlam

Early-Game Progression

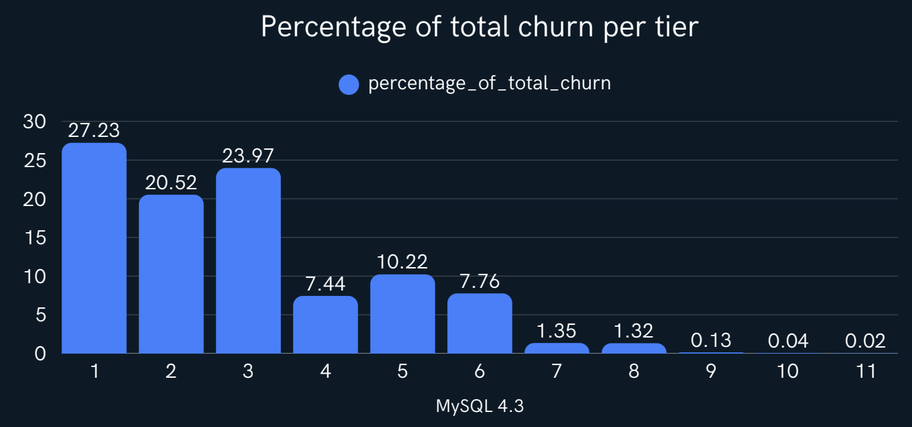
Presented by Thomas Wai on 2026-03-31

Executive Summary

Early-Game Progression Flaws Drive Major Churn in Tiers 1-3.

Churn Concentration

71.7% of early churn occurs in Tiers 1-3, driven by flaws in progression design, leading to players exiting the game before truly engaging with advanced content.



Difficulty Whiplash

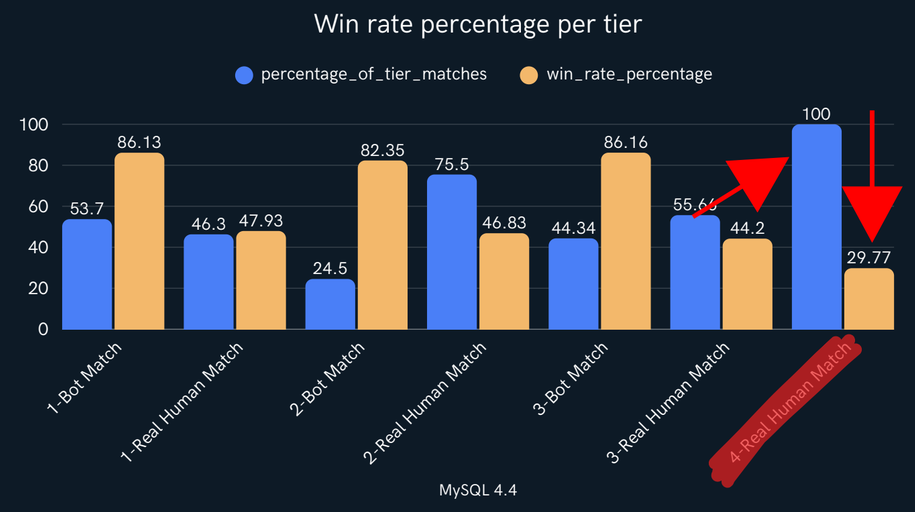
Players experience steep drops in **win rates** transitioning from bots to humans, resulting in frustration and disengagement. Adjustments in matchmaking can smooth this transition and retain more players.

The "Difficulty Whiplash" Effect

Bots Fail to Prepare Players for Real Competition.

Bots vs. Humans

The sudden transition from easy bot matches to challenging human opponents leads to player frustration and increased churn, highlighting flaws in early-game progression design.



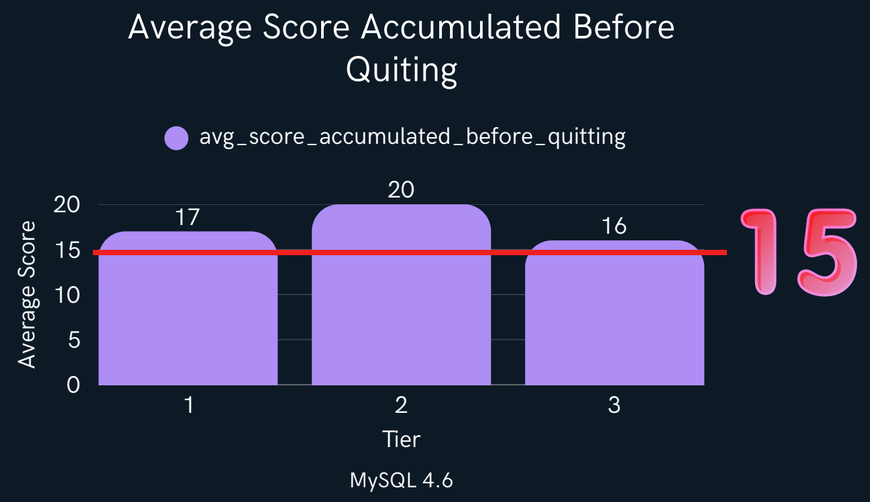
- Tiers 1-3: Players face a high volume of bot matches, maintaining an artificially high win rate of 82%-86%.
- Tier 4: Bots are entirely removed. The human win rate plummets to 29.7%.

The Progression Wall

Early-Game Grind Exceeds Player Patience.

Player Frustration

Players are increasingly experiencing frustration due to excessive early-game grind, leading to churn. Streamlining progression will enhance engagement and retention among new players.

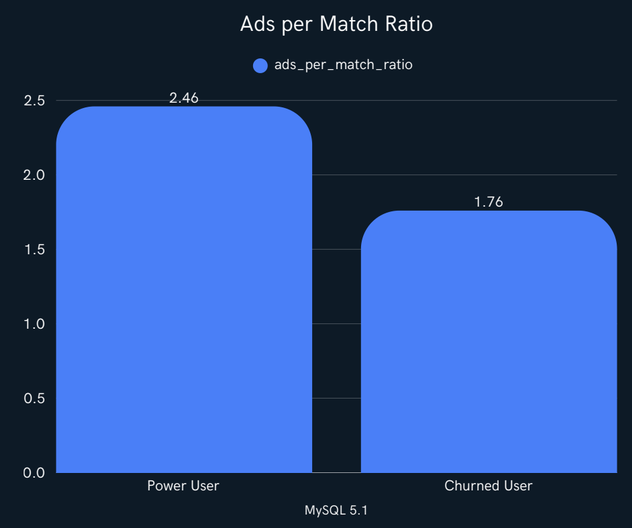


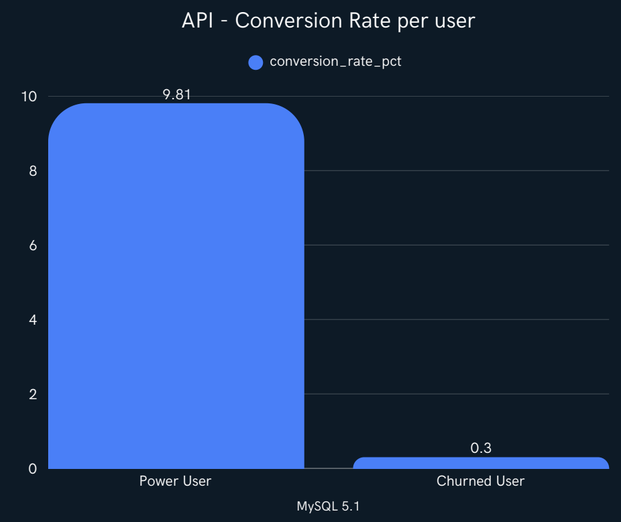
Early Game Churn Tier	Avg. Matches Played Before Quitting	Avg. Score Accumulated
Tier 1	1.6 Matches	17 Points
Tier 2	2.0 Matches	20 Points
Tier 3	1.5 Matches	16 Points

- Churned players only tolerate an average of 1.5 to 2.0 matches per tier before uninstalling.
- They abandon the game after accumulating only 16 to 20 score points.
- Proposed Maximum Tier Requirement (<15 Pts)

Ruling Out Monetisation

Monetisation Friction (Ads & IAP) is Not Driving Churn





Churn Factors

Despite perceptions, **monetisation elements** such as ads and in-app purchases do not significantly drive player churn. Focus remains on gameplay mechanics instead.

- Ad Fatigue is a Myth: Power Users tolerate a heavier ad load (2.46 ads/match) than Churned Users (1.76 ads/match). Players accept ads when they are in the "Flow State" of balanced matchmaking.
- The Conversion Chasm: Power Users are ~33 times more likely to spend money (9.81% conversion) compared to Churned Users (0.30%).
- The "Buyer's Remorse" Cohort: 18 Churned users spent real money (up to £11.97) but still permanently quit within 48 hours.

Product Action Plan & Success Metrics

Product Calls to Action (CTAs):

Compress Progression

Cap Tier 1-3 progression at 15 points to optimise player engagement with fewer matches required.

Dynamic Bot Tapering

Gradually introduce human opponents in Tiers 2-3 to ease the transition and reduce frustration.

Upgrade AI

Enhance early-game bot AI to implement basic human tactics, smoothing the difficulty jump for players.

Tracking Metrics & Success Criteria:

- Primary: Tier 4 Attainment Rate (Goal: Statistically significant increase, $p < 0.05$).
- Secondary: * Lift in Day 1 (D1) and Day 3 (D3) Retention.
    - Reduction in the "Whiplash Delta" (e.g., Bot win rate drops to 70%, early Human win rate rises to 48%).

Product Action Plan & Success Metrics

A/B Testing Plan (14-21 Days):

• Control (Group A): Current tier logic and bot allocation.
• Variant 1 (Group B): Accelerated Progression (Tiers 1-3 require <15 points).
• Variant 2 (Group C): Accelerated Progression + Dynamic Bot Tapering.
• Guardrail Metric: Average Revenue Per User (ARPU). Retention increases must not cause a statistically significant drop in overall ARPU.

Cost & Risk Analysis:

- Engineering: Low for CTA 1 (variable change); Medium/High for CTA 2 & 3 (algorithm updates).
- Cannibalisation Risk: Shorter early game may slightly reduce early ad impressions, which must be offset by higher Lifetime Value (LTV) from retained players.

Thank you

We welcome your inquiries and feedback regarding our findings.